

legend, a European champion and the most-followed individual on Instagram. The 40-year-old, who won the UEFA Nations League last month, was named the brand ambassador of the tournament.

The tournament's opening ceremony will feature American rapper Post Malone, who is an avid gamer too, having played titles like Warzone and PUBG live for fans on the streaming platform, Twitch.

Moreover, Amazon Prime has released a five-part documentary on the tournament, named 'Esports World Cup: Level Up'. Sports docu-series has been a proven avenue to expand reach, with Drive to Survive drawing over 360,000 fans to Formula 1 after its first season.

Another sporting spectacle in Saudi Arabia

Saudi Arabia has emerged as the sporting capital of Asia, hosting major tournaments in football, motorsports, golf and combat sports.

In esports, the country has shone both on and off the gaming stage, producing FIFAe World Cup champions like Mossad 'Msdossary' Al Dossary (*in pic*) and investing USD 37.8 billion through Savvy Games Group, owned by the Public Investment Fund, for the development of gaming.

The inaugural edition of the Esports World Cup was also held in Saudi Arabia last year, and this time, the tournament returns with more titles (26 instead of 22) and a higher prize pool.

Uncharted territory

Among traditional sports, Chess – a touchstone for the brain — has always maintained a niche for itself. So has esports, building its own ecosystem and then making inroads into traditional sporting events.

The World Cup will now see a merger of the two: online chess entering uncharted territory, with a prize pool of USD 1.5 million.

Twelve of the 16 players were selected from the Champions Chess Tour (CCT) 2025, while the final four would be confirmed in the Last Chance Qualifiers (LCQ) later this month.

India will have a chance to shine both as a team

and/or player(s).

At the LCQ, Grandmasters Nihal Sarin and Aravindh Chithambaram from the Indian esports organisation S8UL will have a chance to represent the tricolour, while Praggnanandhaa, the highest-ranking Indian at the time of writing, will compete as part of Dutch organisation, Team Liquid.

Even if all three are unsuccessful in qualifying for the finals, Arjun Erigaisi, representing Gen.G, will still be in contention to make India proud.

Qualified players in Esports World Cup:

Alireza Firouzja, Fabiano Caruana (Team Liquid), Ian Nepomniachtchi (Aurora Gaming), Magnus Carlsen (Team Liquid), Nodirbek Abdusattorov (NAVI), Vladislav Artemiev (Team Spirit), Arjun Erigaisi (Gen.G), Hikaru Nakamura (Team Falcons), Jan-Krzysztof Duda (Twisted Minds), Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (Team Vitality). Vladimir Fedoseev, Wei Yi (Weibo Gaming).



Did you know? Brazil's record goalscorer Neymar will play an esports showmatch in Counter-Strike 2, Rocket League and Tekken 8 at the Esports World Cup 2025.

WHO AM I?

I co-founded my Counter-Strike team with Aakash "RiX" More. My gaming tag contains the word, a synonym for poison, but it's spelt with a "3" instead of an "E"?

The answer will be revealed in the next issue.

Answer to previous issue's quiz:
Raunak "Crowley" Sen



BUSINESS OF ESPORTS

PUBG developer Krafton plans to have an IPL-style esports league in India. It is currently accepting "expressions of interest" from corporates, public figures, athletes, content creators, and investors to take the plan forward.



EASTER EGG 'GANK'

Gank is a strategy where players sneak up on an opponent and attack them by surprise, often teaming up with others. It is commonly used in League of Legends, Dota 2 and Smite.

Rankings and quiz powered by NODWIN Gaming